CHAPTER 8 · DEEP DIVE · A HOUSE DIVIDED

The Atlanta Campaign

The fall of a single city that may have saved Lincoln's presidency — and with it, the Union war effort. 1864.

Name: _____ **Period:** _____ **Date:** _____

The fall of a single city that may have saved Lincoln's presidency — and with it, the Union war effort. 1864.

How can the capture of one city change the outcome of an election a thousand miles away?

A War-Weary North

SUMMER 1864

By mid-1864 the North was exhausted. Grant's campaign in Virginia had produced staggering casualty lists and no clear victory. Many Northerners wanted the war to end — even if it meant letting the South go.

Lincoln faced reelection in November, and he privately believed he would lose. His opponent's party ran on a platform calling the war a "failure." Everything now depended on a Union victory that would prove the war could be won.

"Battle of Atlanta, July 22, 1864" — chromolithograph, Kurz & Allison, public domain (Library of Congress).

On to Atlanta

SHERMAN'S DRIVE

Far to the south, General William Tecumseh Sherman was driving through Georgia toward Atlanta — a rail and manufacturing center vital to the Confederacy. Through a long campaign of maneuver and battle, he pressed the Confederate army back toward the city.

On September 2, 1864, Atlanta fell. Sherman wired Washington: "Atlanta is ours, and fairly won."

The destroyed railroad roundhouse, Atlanta — photograph by George N. Barnard, 1864, public domain (Library of Congress).

The Battle of Atlanta

JULY 22, 1864

The fighting around Atlanta was fierce — this print shows the battle in which the Union general James McPherson was killed. But the city could not hold.

"Battle of Atlanta — Death of General McPherson, July 22, 1864" — chromolithograph, Kurz & Allison, public domain (Library of Congress).

What Victory Looked Like

ATLANTA, 1864

Before leaving on his March to the Sea, Sherman burned Atlanta's war resources. This photograph shows the ruins of the railroad roundhouse — the shattered heart of a Confederate supply hub.

The destroyed railroad roundhouse, Atlanta — photograph by George N. Barnard, 1864, public domain (Library of Congress).

The Victory That Reelected Lincoln

WHY IT MATTERS

The timing was everything. The fall of Atlanta, just two months before the election, proved the war could be won. War-weariness turned to confidence, and in November Lincoln was reelected in a landslide.

This is what historians call contingency — the idea that history could have gone differently. Had Atlanta not fallen when it did, Lincoln might have lost, a peace candidate might have won, and the Confederacy might have survived. One campaign, at one moment, changed everything.

Turning points, 1863–65 — map, © ShadowDog Digital Studios (SDS Digital Collection).

Weigh the What-Ifs

YOUR TURN

You'll practice contingency — reasoning about how one event made others possible, and what might have happened if the timing had been different.